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Comic relief: It was a sight we have all encountered in our childhood — a frantic search for a lost cricket ball. After a break in play that lasted more than 10 minutes, the umpires decided to call time on the old ball and whipped out a new one. **B. JOTHIRAMALINGAM**

What ensued was a sight we have all encountered in our childhood — a frantic search for a lost cricket ball. The hunting party consisted of a few ground staff and a couple of Goan players. After a brief perusal of the inner part of the compound, they concluded that the ball had indeed squirmed through the gate and into the road (the Diary did a mental fist pump).

As one of the ground staff scaled the gate — why didn't they unlock it though? — and foraged on the road, the rest of the players on the ground decided to have a short afternoon siesta. The Diary counted six players, including a Kerala batter, lying on the ground, quietly pondering the unfolding absurdity.

After a break in play that lasted more than 10 minutes, the umpires decided to call time on the old ball and whipped out a new one, much to the joy of the Goan side, which stumbled upon a shinier ball to work with. Just as the match resumed and Tendulkar finished his over, a ground staff member managed to retrieve the 'lost ball', which was soon taken into custody by the fourth umpire.

All in all, a good day of 'work' for the Diary.

Pranay Rajiv

The quiet grind

First-Class cricket grants its practitioners bragging rights — enduring a season is hailed as the purest, truest test of resolve.

List A is lucrative in its own right, momentary surges often catapulting players to stratospheric fame. The Indian Premier League (IPL) has only

expanded these avenues. But List A does not quite embody the rigours of lending oneself to a five-month process of turning up day after day, game after game.

And the test extends itself beyond the field too, which the Diary found out during a brief encounter with the Jammu & Kashmir (J&K) team **(below)**, in transit to its Ranji Trophy quarterfinal stop, Indore, where it will lock horns with Madhya Pradesh.

J&K is a team turning a corner. It has been a familiar face in the Ranji Trophy knockouts lately, but this group has to get the monkey off its back — of faltering in the quarterfinals. Last season was agonising in particular, with Kerala squeezing through to the semifinals courtesy of a one-run first-innings lead.

This season, J&K was runner-up in Group B with only a solitary loss in seven games. It came at the hands of heavyweight Mumbai, which too had to expend itself to the hilt to eke out a 35-run win. A big campaign is in the works for J&K.

But as the team set off for its knockout, merely a day after concluding its seventh-round match

in Badaun, Himachal Pradesh, its weariness, worth seven rounds of cricket on either side of white-ball tournaments, made itself evident.

There was hardly a word between players as they awaited their boarding call. One had his head on the table, in the confines of his folded arms, catching a quick shut-eye. At another table, pacer Umar Nazir Mir was unpacking his Subway sandwich, using the break to complete his protein targets.

Abdul Samad had taken the retreat of his sunglasses and baseball cap in one corner, hoping to avoid requests for pictures, which he would otherwise happily grant in a slightly better setting. The Diary extended a greeting to Yudhvir Singh Charak, whom it had met earlier, but his weary smile made his intention of being left alone clear, even if his words did not.

This interlude must be invaluable for the players — a momentary snooze before they are back on the field. In a calendar that is meant to draw from one's deepest reserves, the brief hush that fell on the team was perhaps well earned.

Abhishek Saini



SHIV KUMAR PUSHPAKAR